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CAPTAINCY – THE FIRST STINT

Captaining India is undoubtedly a great honour, and it was a job I felt ready for at that point in my career. I had captained Mumbai and led them to victory in the Ranji Trophy in 1995–96. In all, I captained Mumbai in sixteen out of the thirty-eight Ranji Trophy matches I played in, and I continued to do well as a batsman in these games, scoring at an average of 99.53. I had also captained West Zone in the Duleep Trophy, so it wasn't an altogether new experience. Yet captaining India is fundamentally different, with its own particular challenges.

First, there is the need to cope with the demands of the non-stop media machine. The Indian captain's every move is headline news and it was no easy task to protect myself from the constant media glare. More important, perhaps, was learning how to deal with the selection committee and the practice of zonal representation associated with it.

In India the committee consists of five selectors, one from each zone: West, North, South, East and Central. Zonal representation sometimes resulted in selectors pushing players from their particular zone and in my first stint as captain the team undoubtedly suffered as a consequence. There were occasions when I wasn't given the team of my choice and did not get particular players I asked for. For me, the priority was always the Indian team. For some of the selectors, however, things may have been different. I felt there were other factors dictating team selection and at times I felt disappointed after selection committee meetings.

A promising start